

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 22

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A teenager performs card and coin tricks on a children's hospital ward as a volunteer, and learns what it costs to amuse strangers.

1

The lift opened on the seventh floor with a small, polite chime, and for one cowardly moment I considered riding back down. I was sixteen, dressed in the maroon polo shirt that marked me out as a hospital volunteer, and the deck of cards in my pocket suddenly felt absurdly heavy. Down the corridor, beyond the double doors, lay the children's ward. I had practised in front of my bedroom mirror for two months. I had practised in front of my long-suffering grandmother. I had not, until now, practised in front of anyone who might not laugh.

2

The trick to a card trick, my uncle had once told me, is not the trick. It is the small misdirection — the lifted eyebrow, the hand that points away from the hand that matters, the quiet word at the moment your audience expects a flourish. I had memorised this advice the way other boys memorise football statistics. It still did not prepare me for the first bed.

3

Her name, the nurse said, was Aisyah, and she was seven. She watched me approach with the steady, sceptical gaze of someone who has already, in her short life, been promised too many things. I knelt beside the bed so that my eyes were level with hers, fanned the cards into a clumsy arc, and asked her to pick one. She picked the four of clubs. I knew this because I had cut the deck. She did not need to know. When, three minutes later, I produced the four of clubs from beneath her water jug, her small mouth opened into a perfect O, and something in my chest, which had been knotted since the lift, loosened by a single notch.

4

I worked my way down the ward. A boy with a bandaged arm learned that his chosen card had migrated, mysteriously, into my shoe. A pair of identical twins, who had been bickering before I arrived, suddenly

agreed about something for the first time that morning: that the coin which had disappeared from one twin's palm could not, possibly, have re-appeared in the other twin's ear. Their mother laughed so hard she had to look away. I began, very cautiously, to enjoy myself.

5

Then I reached the last bed by the window, and my courage faltered. The boy in it was perhaps eight years old. His head was bare; a thin tube ran from his arm to a softly beeping machine. He did not look up when I greeted him. He did not look up when I fanned the cards. He looked, instead, at the ceiling tiles, with the fixed expression of a child who has decided, on some private principle, not to be cheered up by anyone in a maroon polo shirt.

6

I stood there foolishly for a long moment. Every line I had rehearsed deserted me. I could feel the nurse watching from the desk, and the boy's mother watching from the chair, and the boy himself not watching at all. I almost moved on. Then I remembered my uncle's other rule, the one I had nearly forgotten: that if a trick is not working, you do not try harder. You try smaller. I put the cards away. I took out a single fifty-cent coin and, without saying anything, balanced it on the back of my own hand. I balanced a second on top of it, then a third. The boy's eyes flicked, just once, sideways.

7

I flipped my hand over. The three coins, by a technique I had practised eight hundred times against my grandmother's kitchen wall, did not fall. They clung, impossibly, to my upturned palm. The boy stared. Then, slowly, as though grudgingly granting me a favour he had not meant to grant, the corner of his mouth lifted by perhaps a millimetre. It was not a laugh. It was not even, strictly, a smile. But his mother caught my eye over his head, and the look she gave me was one I have not, in the years since, ever quite forgotten.

8

I rode the lift back down at six o'clock, my cards a little dog-eared and my coins warm in my pocket. The maroon polo shirt no longer felt like a costume. I thought, on the way home, that I had gone in expecting to give the children something. I had not expected, in return, to be given anything at all.

From Paragraph 1

1. In Paragraph 1, the narrator says that the deck of cards “suddenly felt absurdly heavy.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about how he felt as he stepped out of the lift. [2]

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show the narrator had prepared seriously for this morning. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. According to the narrator's uncle, what is the real “trick” behind a card trick? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator says Aisyah watched him with “the steady, sceptical gaze of someone who has already, in her short life, been promised too many things.” What does this suggest about Aisyah? [2]

5. Explain what the narrator means when he says that “something in my chest, which had been knotted since the lift, loosened by a single notch.” [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 4 that shows the narrator was beginning to relax. [1]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says the boy by the window had “the fixed expression of a child who has decided, on some private principle, not to be cheered up by anyone in a maroon polo shirt.” Explain how the language of this sentence makes the boy seem **determined** in his refusal. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator says, “if a trick is not working, you do not try harder. You try smaller.” What does this advice suggest about how to deal with a difficult audience? [2]

9. The narrator describes the boy’s eyes flicking “just once, sideways.” Why is this small detail **important** at this point in the story? [1]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator says the boy’s smile lifted “by perhaps a millimetre.” What does this very small measurement suggest about the success of the trick? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: A feature article on the decline of handwriting in the digital era.****1**

A generation ago, a child entering primary school could expect to spend a substantial portion of each week on the slow, painstaking craft of forming letters by hand. Loops were traced and re-traced; pencils were sharpened and resharpened; a teacher walked the rows, gently correcting the angle of a wrist. Today, that ritual has thinned almost to vanishing. A 2022 survey of primary schools in England found that the average pupil now spends less than fifteen minutes a day on dedicated handwriting practice, down from over an hour in the 1990s. In Singapore, the introduction of personal learning devices from Primary 4 onwards has shifted classroom note-taking decisively towards the keyboard. The pencil, it seems, has been quietly retired.

2

The reasons for the shift are, on the surface, sensible. Typed work is faster to produce, easier to mark, and trivially simple to share. A child who types her composition does not smudge the ink, lose the page, or labour for an extra hour because her cursive is unreadable. Teachers, drowning in marking, can scarcely be blamed for welcoming the change. Parents, similarly, often see typing as a more “future-ready” skill — one that prepares their children for a working life lived almost entirely on a screen.

3

Yet a growing body of cognitive research has begun to suggest that something important is lost when the pen is set aside. A widely cited study by researchers at Princeton and the University of California in 2014 asked students to take notes on a lecture either by hand or on a laptop. Those who wrote by hand remembered the **conceptual** content of the lecture noticeably better a week later, even though the laptop users had recorded a far greater volume of text. The mechanism, the researchers proposed, was simple. Because writing by hand is slower, the writer cannot transcribe verbatim; she must select, condense, and rephrase — and that selection is itself an act of learning.

4

More recent neuroscience has reinforced the picture. A 2020 study in Norway used electroencephalography — the recording of brainwave activity — to compare children writing letters by hand with children typing the same letters. Handwriting activated a wider, more synchronised network of regions associated with memory and learning. Typing, by contrast, produced a noticeably narrower pattern of activity. None of this is to claim that typing is harmful, or that handwriting alone makes a child clever. It is, however, to suggest that the two activities are not, neurologically speaking, the same.

5

There is also a cultural counter-movement. Calligraphy classes, in cities from London to Seoul to Singapore, have quietly multiplied since the late 2010s. Bullet-journaling — the practice of keeping a hand-drawn, often elaborately illustrated planner — has spread through universities and offices, particularly among young adults who spend their working day looking at a screen. A 2023 industry report on the global stationery market found that sales of fountain pens, against every reasonable expectation, had grown for six years in succession. Something is happening, and it is not nostalgia alone. It is, one suspects, the discovery that the hand wants to make marks of its own.

6

None of this is an argument for turning back the clock. Laptops and tablets bring real and important advantages to a modern classroom. Children with dyslexia or fine-motor difficulties can write at length on a keyboard when a pencil would have defeated them. Pupils in remote villages can, through a single shared tablet, access libraries unimaginable to their grandparents. To insist on handwriting alone, in the name of tradition, would be to deny those children real opportunity.

7

What is needed, then, is not a return but a balance. The best schools are already moving in this direction — keeping handwriting as a daily, deliberate practice in the early years, while introducing typing later, with care. Teachers are being encouraged to ask not “pen or screen?” but “pen **and** screen, at the right moments, for the right tasks”. Whether parents and policymakers will support such a balance, or quietly drift towards the cheaper, easier all-keyboard classroom, depends on whether we still believe that **how** a child writes matters as much as **what** she writes. The pencil, in short, has not yet had its last word.

From Paragraph 1

12. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show how much time used to be spent on handwriting in schools. [2]

13. The writer says that “the pencil, it seems, has been quietly retired.” Explain, in your own words, what this sentence suggests about the change. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** practical reasons why teachers and parents have welcomed the shift towards typing. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer puts the word “conceptual” in italics. What is the writer’s purpose in emphasising this word? [1]

16. The researchers concluded that writing by hand makes a writer “select, condense, and rephrase” what she hears. Explain, in your own words, why this process helps her learn. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that handwriting and typing “are not, neurologically speaking, the same.” Why does the writer take care to add the qualifier “neurologically speaking”? [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. Give **two** pieces of evidence from Paragraph 5 that support the writer’s claim that there is a “cultural counter-movement” against the decline of handwriting. [2]

19. The writer ends Paragraph 5 by saying that “the hand wants to make marks of its own.” What does this phrase suggest about why people are returning to handwriting? [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. In Paragraph 6, the writer gives examples of children who **benefit** from typing rather than handwriting. What is the writer’s **purpose** in including these examples? [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the text by saying that “the pencil... has not yet had its last word.” Explain what is **effective** about this final image. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the benefits of writing by hand** and **the cultural and practical reasons handwriting is returning**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Writing by hand brings several benefits, beginning with ...

— END OF PAPER —